

01

CONCEPTUAL METHOD: WHAT PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

[THESIS] The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Evil can rebut or undercut a proof, but this session does not repeat the proofs.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched.

ANSWER LINE: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

02

CLASSICAL FORMULATION AND MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

[VERDICT] Mackie's argument remains pedagogically decisive because it forces the theist to state the hidden moral and modal assumptions.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The dilemma is transmitted in later discussion, prominently through Lactantius, and Hume's Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion gives a celebrated modern formulation through Philo.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Omnipotence means power to do what is logically possible, not power to instantiate contradictions.

ANSWER LINE: The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

03

PLANTINGA'S FREE WILL DEFENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

If so, God's inability to actualize freedom-with-guaranteed-goodness is not lack of omnipotence, because the proposed object is not a feasible world God can strongly actualize.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

If God causally determines every significantly free choice to be right, the choice is not libertarianly free in relation to God.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

[OBJECTION] Why could God not create free persons who always freely choose the good, as the blessed might in heaven?

ANSWER LINE: The defence is strongest for moral evil.

04

EVIDENTIAL EVIL: ROWE, PROBABILITY AND SKEPTICAL THEISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

We should prevent suffering because we lack authority to assume an unknown justifying plan.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The case is illustrative, not a claim that one event alone deductively disproves God.

ANSWER LINE: Evidential force depends on a noseenum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

05

CLASSICAL THEODICIES AND DEFENCES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Augustine treats evil as a privation of good arising through created freedom, not as a positive substance created by God.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

[QUALIFICATION] What it preserves or explains: It addresses moral and natural evil within one developmental framework and explains why God is not overwhelmingly evident.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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06

NON-CLASSICAL THEISMS AND REVISED DIVINE ATTRIBUTES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

God is not the author of evil and receives the world's suffering in divine experience.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Reality consists in becoming actualities with their own measure of self-determination; God supplies persuasive possibilities but cannot simply coerce every event.

ANSWER LINE: Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology.

07

EXISTENTIAL EVIL, PROTEST AND HORRENDOUS EVILS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

It should not be reduced to a neat punishment theory.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

[THESIS] Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

[THESIS] Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

They are not substitutes for formal argument; they test its existential and ethical adequacy.

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INDIAN AND NON-WESTERN FRAMEWORKS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma (morally consequential action) and liberation.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

[THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Nyaya (school of logic and realism): Ishvara (Lord or personal God) can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator.

ANSWER LINE: Karma (morally consequential action) is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim.

HARD CASES AND META-LEVEL CRITIQUES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

[VERDICT] The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.

ANSWER LINE: Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

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10

COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Theodicies should be compared through the divine attribute revised, the evil explained, the residual case and the moral cost of the explanation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Protest: need not be unbelief; Job-like protest can occur within a relationship.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Agents must prevent avoidable suffering because they are not entitled to assume it is necessary.

ANSWER LINE: Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.